

THE REAL FATE OF THE WATERLOO FALLEN

■ *The exploitation of bones in 19th century Belgium*

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What happened to the bodies of those killed at the Battle of Waterloo? Generations of historians have tried to find an answer to this and it is the one most commonly asked questions of those who visit the plain of Waterloo, the battlefield and the local museums today.¹ Between 10,000 and 20,000 men and, often forgotten, many thousands of horses were killed on that fateful day of 18 June 1815. Early visitors to the battlefield have recounted and documented, either in writing or in works of art, what happened on the battlefield once the guns had fallen silent. The dead, corpses of men and beast alike, were stripped and hastily buried in mass graves.² But despite the abundant documentation it has since then been impossible to locate these burials and archaeologists have thus far excavated only two human skeletons, the first in 2012 and the second in 2022, despite ever more sophisticated archaeological techniques.³